Adaptability questions

Design Gurus

Amazon runs its behavioral interviews against sixteen named Leadership Principles. Almost every question in an Amazon loop is chosen to produce evidence for one of them.

How the loop works

You will usually meet four or five interviewers. Each is assigned two or three principles in advance, and they overlap only a little. Between them the loop covers most of the sixteen.

Each interviewer writes up your answers under the principles they were given. They use direct quotes where they can get them. Those write-ups go to a hiring meeting where the discussion is about the evidence, not the impression.

One interviewer in the loop is a Bar Raiser. They come from outside the hiring team and are trained for the role. They can block an offer. Their job is to check that you are stronger than the median person already doing that job.

Two things follow. Vague answers cost you more here than elsewhere, because the write-up needs something quotable. And consistency matters, because four write-ups that disagree get noticed in the meeting.

The sixteen principles, and what each asks you to show

The name is what Amazon calls it. The line after it is what you actually have to demonstrate.

Customer Obsession. That you started from the customer's problem rather than the technical one. Also that you know who your customer was.

Ownership. That you acted beyond your assigned task, and did not stop at "that was another team's job".

Invent and Simplify. That you removed something, not only that you built something.

Are Right, A Lot. That your judgment was sound with incomplete information, and that you can say how you knew.

Learn and Be Curious. That you learned something new because the work required it, not because it interested you.

Hire and Develop the Best. That somebody got better because of you, with evidence of what they could do afterwards.

Insist on the Highest Standards. That you refused to ship something, and what that cost you.

Think Big. That you proposed something larger than your remit, and can explain the reasoning behind it.

Bias for Action. That you moved without complete information, and that you knew which decisions were reversible.

Frugality. That you got the result with fewer people, less money, or less time than expected.

Earn Trust. That you were honest about a mistake, or took criticism well.

Dive Deep. That you went to the data yourself rather than accepting a summary.

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit. That you disagreed with somebody senior, and then committed fully once the decision went against you.

Deliver Results. That you finished, with a number.

Strive to be Earth's Best Employer. That you improved something about how your team worked, not only what it produced.

Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility. That you considered the effect of your work beyond the immediate user.

The four candidates are least ready for

These come up constantly, and they are the ones people arrive without.

Have Backbone needs a story where you disagreed with a manager or a senior engineer. Most candidates only have a peer disagreement ready, and a peer disagreement does not answer the question.

Dive Deep needs a story where the summary you were handed was wrong and you found out by looking yourself. A general statement about liking data fails this.

Earn Trust is most often asked as a mistake or a failure. A candidate with no failure story loses it outright.

Frugality is not about being cheap. It is about a constraint you worked inside. A story where you asked for more people and got them does not answer it.

The last two principles

Amazon added Strive to be Earth's Best Employer and Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility to the original fourteen. They are asked less often, and more often at senior levels than junior ones.

You do not need a dedicated story for either one. What helps is being able to answer two questions about a story you already have. What did it mean for the people doing the work, and for anyone outside the immediate user?